Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Nicki Parrott

Bassist/vocalist Nicki Parrott immigrated to the U.S. from Australia in 1994. She quickly became a sought after rhythm section player and currently appears at jazz venues across the U.S. and abroad. She records as a leader on Arbors Records.

Nicki was interviewed in Utica, New York on November 6, 2010 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm off-camera, but I'm very pleased to have Nicki Parrott here as a guest for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Welcome back to Utica.

NP: Thank you. Always good to be here.

MR: It's interesting, we talked, well you were here a few weeks ago and you mentioned that you were coming back, and playing Klezmer music. I got the impression you weren't really sure what you were going to be doing or who was playing, and is that a sort of a typical situation that you find yourself in?

NP: Sometimes you get band leaders that will tell you every single detail, almost too much detail, and then you get the complete opposite where you're not sure what time the gig is, where the gig is, if you'll eat, where the hotel is. Sometimes you're in the dark. But I've worked with David Krakauer, the artist tonight, on and off for the last ten years, mostly in Europe because he's actually a big star in France. He had — a French record label put out a lot of records in France, so I've toured a lot in Europe with him and he's one of the best clarinetists I've worked with.

MR: Is the music more popular over there? His kind of music?

NP: Yes. He does his version of Klezmer music so he has kind of, he mixes it with jazz or funk, whatever. He did a wonderful album a long time ago which was a tribute to Sidney Bechet, so it was his version of playing Klezmer with that early Sidney Bechet kind of music and he joined them together. And it came out very interesting. He's a very interesting artist. So he does a sort of a mix of that traditional Klezmer which you might even hear at a bar mitzvah or a Jewish wedding or something, and mixed with all of his — he's an extraordinary classical musician, so he mixes some of that with some jazz, some funk, and it comes out, you know, so some of it's traditional and some of it's like this —

MR: And you've got to find your place in that music.

NP: Yeah.

MR: Which I think is a big part of being a musician, especially a bass player. You've got to figure out what's the situation here. How do you gain that musical knowledge?

NP: Um. Well it's funny, there are different ways to lead a band, you know, and now that I'm a band leader myself a lot I'm learning how to do it and get the results and get the respect and everything, and there are some people, like when I was up here last time I worked with Dick Hyman here, and I also worked with Dick Hyman earlier in the year at Merlin's. And someone like Dick doesn't really want to tell you how to play but might give you a guideline, you know what I mean? Like well I think you sing that song better, or just come in after a couple of choruses. And that's like you get a little bit of a guideline but he'll never tell you actually how to play the gig. And so I think you've got to use your best judgement. But you have to learn ahead of the gig. I always tell students that. You have to, unless you're leading you don't play bass solos behind the clarinet solo. You know? You don't do that. You play what the gig requires, which, for me, is a groove, it's time, it's a feel, it's a sound. And I love accompanying. So I'm always finding out — if the drum is getting really busy I might play simple. If it's getting exciting well I might rhythmically push too. You know what I mean? So you have to kind of just keep your wits about you. But I think what the thing about being a bass player is you really like the groove. So if it's all going crazy around you you've got to be like the center and be like I'm not going to let this slow down or go out the window, you've really got to keep your center and just try to make all of that work somehow. Sometimes it does, sometimes not so well.

MR: That's great advice. I've often felt that the bass player really is the lynchpin of the whole thing. I mean you can send the music in a direction if you want to, I mean if you want to start swinging and the rest of the band is playing in two, you can sort of like say no, we're going this way.

NP: Yeah.

MR: And you have a lot of power it seems to me.

NP: It is, and sometimes you play with — if I'm at a gig say, and I remember being on the gig once with Jeff Hamilton out in California, a wonderful drummer. Now when I was playing with Jeff, and we hadn't played together before, I'm going to let Jeff lead, even though he may not be leading the set, you know what I mean, but we're in a trio or a quartet and someone's out front playing, I forget who it was at the time. But my eyes were on Jeff. Whatever Jeff does I'm going to — so I noticed when he was in two, and I just tried to follow his lead. Some drummers are really good at leading and you can just follow along. And other times you feel like you know what I mean, you can take more of it. It's really a communication. I like the communication between bass players and drummers. It makes the music that much more tighter.

MR: Is there such a thing as playing, you hear the term, playing on top of the beat or behind the beat?

NP: Yeah.

MR: Is that a reality?

NP: Well I think about that less and less. I thought about it when I was younger and when I had a lesson with Ray Brown, who was known for playing on top of the beat so to speak, or other musicians would say he played really on top of the beat. When I asked Ray about it Ray was like well, he said, "I like to give the music an edge but I don't like it to get too fast, but I like it to have an edge." So he liked to really propel the beat I think, you know what I mean? Whether you call that top of the beat or whatever. And, you know, I don't like to think about it. Because I think what happens is when you are a freelancer in these days there are very few bands where you're playing with the same person all the time you know. So if you're a freelancer you're going to get some drummers that really play very laid back, which gives you a little more authority to play. The two things, you just don't want it to speed up and you don't want it to slow down. So you have to kind of find — you know if the drummer plays so far back well then you've got to really push the beat, you know what I mean? Because otherwise it's going to drag. If the drummer is rushing and — I find it harder to play with the rushing drummer, and I have to think about this when I'm booking my own gigs, you know what I mean? If I'm trying to play a note, I'm singing more, I don't want a drummer that's pushing the beat too much because I'm trying to like, you know, keep it there. And so that's even harder because you've really got to put the anchor on their beat, and that takes a lot of concentration too. So it really depends on who you're playing with, this on top of the beat, behind the beat. The main thing is the horn player wants you to keep it at the tempo that it was kind of off at, or somewhere in there, because they've got to play the head on the way in and they've got to play the head on the way out. If it gets too fast for them to play the head out, they're not exactly happy with the rhythm section then are they? So it's really, like for me it's a responsibility of keeping the time within a reasonable — you know if it's kind of there [snaps fingers] it's your job as a bass player, to keep it around there. And I find the best musicians really do that, you know what I mean? And so that's why you don't even think about it with great drummers and great piano players. It just flows. Because everybody knows where the beat is and it's just — I had one of those nights the other night. You know I played with a drummer for the first time, and it's just so nice when you hear the beat exactly the same place. And he was trying all kinds of stuff on the drums. Alvin Atkinson. Wonderful. He was just going for it. And the gig had this lovely looseness, so it was like yeah, just go for it. But it was always, when we came back in to play it was always just there.

MR: Well when you book your own gigs as a leader, I'm curious about your phone book or whatever. Do you have indicators of —

NP: No.

MR: But you probably have people that you want to call in a certain order.

NP: And sometimes for me it's about the gig. Sometimes I think it might be a gig where they want it more traditional. So sometimes I might hire Rossano Sportiello over John DiMartino, do you know what I mean? It depends musically on what they want sometimes too. I kind of have a pool of musicians I try to get, basically.

MR: Well you mentioned, amongst the things that you think about when you play, you think about sound. Is there a way that you can, as a bass player, how do you distinguish your own bass playing from any other thing.

NP: That's a very hard thing. I think it's hard on any instrument these days, with all the influences out there. You know you've got to steal from the best. You know, you do, we all do. We've all had, listen I worked for Les Paul for quite a while. And sometimes I'll go back and listen to old Les Paul and go wow that's like Charlie Christian. You know what I mean? Like some of the really early stuff, with a little Django in there perhaps and other people that he was listening to at the time that were around. And myself the first bass player I fell in love with was Paul Chambers. Now when I play the bass I still love the way Paul Chambers and Oscar Pettiford played the bass, so that's still kind of, even if it's way unconscious it's still a part of what I like about bass playing was those guys. And then of course Ray Brown and I listen to Ron Carter, I listen to Milt Hinton a lot and Bobby Haggart, I got to meet him a couple of times. I sort of came to New York to have a good time in your life or something like that. So it's very hard — your own sound — you just have a sound that you want to go for. And then now, because you can't really travel with a bass that much these days with the airlines the way they are. So I like the challenge of trying to get a good sound, or trying to get my sound out of all these different instruments you come up with. Because sometimes you can get a bass that's better than yours. I was in Switzerland a few weeks back and I got a bass that was way better than my one at home. So that gives you another perspective, it's like wow, if I had a bass that sounded like this I could play this and I could do that.

MR: Yeah, I think saxophone and trumpet players forget about that situation, that if you were going to fly to a gig and okay here's your saxophone, it's like, I can't play that, or that's tricky.

NP: Well with the bass you have a lot of variables. You have ones set up for symphony orchestras, ones that haven't been played in fifty years, and ones that weren't really set up for jazz, ones that have a pick-up, sometimes they don't, you know. Sometimes there's so much dust on them and it's crazy the variables. Piano players complain about it, because the piano variables are really inherent. Bass variables — drums too. Drums can

get pretty wide in their sort of sound. You've got rock drums. They'll set up a set of rock drums for you and it's a little tiny jazz gig.

MR: Well let me see if I can get a sense of when you were 12 or 13, in Australia, right?

NP: Yeah.

MR: Did you have visions of doing what you're doing now? Did you have aspirations at that age?

NP: You know all I know is for me it was sports and music growing up. My dad was quite an athlete, you know, and my dad was a big influence. In fact I'm taking my dad on a jazz cruise next week, I mean next month. So he's coming to New York and we're going on the Arbors jazz cruise.

MR: Oh right.

NP: Down in Florida. And he loves it. And he's funny. But when I was growing up it was athletics and music. And for me the turning point, it's funny you say 12 or 13, because I think I was around that age, or perhaps 14. I went down and I was playing classical piano and classical flute in school bands and local bands. And I was in a band when I was 13 called the Marching Koalas. And I played piccolo and marched in the Rose Parade in Pasadena, playing piccolo, in the Marching Koalas. No kidding. So I was involved in a lot of musical things, but then I also had this thing where I was into sprinting. I was a sprinter. You know, so I was going to like the state championship in like 100 meter, 200, maybe 400 and hurdles and the relay and all that stuff. So I was in four events. And I returned one time and I realized that I'd have to work really hard to get to that next level of being an athlete. It sort of dawned on me. Because I'd been winning all these without too much training, you know what I mean? Like my dad would train me down at the park and that was sort of good enough. So I hit this point when I was like 14 and I was in the state championships and I had gotten like fourth place in the heat or something and I was like oh, wow, okay. And then I made the finals or something. But I either went to the final of this race, or I went to a piano theory exam. They clashed. The times clashed. And I was sitting with my dad and my dad said, "What do you want to do?" And I said, "I'm going to the theory exam." You know I didn't want to humiliate myself in case I came in last. And it dawned on me, this athletic thing is, if I really wanted to pursue that seriously, that's going to be a lot harder work than playing music. And music was always much more a part of me at that stage, do you know what I mean, from five years old going to piano lessons and then to school band and the flute. I mean it was really a thread through my whole early years and high school. So I knew I wanted to be a musician. Where? I don't know. I had no. I didn't even know New York existed back then really. I mean I'm on the other side of the world, close to Sydney. Sydney I was drawn to. So I was drawn to big cities. And really it was six years in Sydney, after six years in Sydney

then I decided to come to New York. Because when I was in Sydney I started hearing about New York. When I was in Newcastle, all I heard about was Sydney as far as music goes. You know what I mean? So when I got to Sydney then I heard talking about New York, and I thought well maybe I should check out New York.

MR: And your sister was sort of preceding you in this musical endeavor?

NP: Yes. She also played piano and clarinet and tenor sax, and she got some records around then. I was 14, she was 16, something like that. And she came home with all these records, Charlie Parker, Louis Armstrong, everything. I don't even know how she got half these records but she came home with all these records, and then she formed a band, right? You've probably heard this story.

MR: I'm not sure.

NP: Yeah. She formed a band, and she said, "I don't need a flute player in my band." And I looked up to her so much back then, and I still do, you know, she's always been a good musician, my sister, you know what I mean? She's always had her own mind, her own sound, really her own voice from a young age. I really feel that about her. She's just full of her own ambition musically, throughout her life. Very interesting. And so like okay. But there was a bass at school. And she said, "Do you want to be in my band, I need a bass player." So lo and behold there was a bass at school and a guy across the road that kind of played bass in a Dixieland band in Newcastle, with three strings. It didn't even have four strings on it. He says no one hears the bottom string, don't worry about it, just three strings are enough.

MR: That's funny.

NP: Yeah. So I was set up with the bass and I kind of taught myself. Because I didn't know he teaches in Newcastle at the time.

MR: That's interesting how those little things happen in your life that send you in a certain direction for almost ever. You know, like your sister saying, "Well I need a bass player."

NP: Yeah it is bizarre. It is bizarre. But when you're young and you've got the time, you know what I mean, you've got the time to just search things out. In the pre-computer age. Do you know what I mean? I was of the generation that computers were brought into the high school but they weren't taken seriously. They were like well we really don't have enough computers for you to take computer class. Oh okay. So I was that transition kid where it was the start of the technological age but not really embraced yet, you know what I mean? So we had oodles of time to practice, to do athletics, practice after school activities, school band, concert band, local bands, you name it. We were in everything. The Marching Koalas.

MR: The Marching Koalas.

NP: Yeah.

MR: Why is it that — I mean this is not really a musical question so much, but you are taking about young people had more time pre-computers. What is that about?

NP: Well I don't know, it just seems like there's a lot more distractions now. Meaning that we didn't have the Facebook, we didn't have email. I don't know. It's hard to say. That's a hard question because certain kids are more disciplined that others. And I mean really, these days, if you're going to get work done and really trying to succeed with something, you've got to limit your time on Facebook, you've got to limit your time on email. You know what I mean? Whereas back then there was not that and we weren't allowed to watch too much TV and I wasn't as interested in TV as I was trying to work on a Schumann piano piece.

MR: Okay.

NP: So I don't know. For me it's just I hid behind music a bit too. I grew up in a religious house and all of that didn't really appeal to me too much so music was a little way out for me. I notice this with kids that I teach now. Their time is so, you know, I mean chopped up with, it seems like there's more pressure on kids too, academically, because we're in different economic times. You know what I mean? There's more pressure on kids these days.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Well you were able to come to the United States on a grant?

NP: Yeah.

MR: At that time did you think you know what — I think I could make a living at this. Did you come here with that idea or did it sort of evolve?

NP: Well that's a good question because who knows. When you come to a city like New York, I mean you really have to know that once you emigrate to a country where things are done slightly different than Australia, it's really, I like that expression "get in line." Look how many bass players have really made their mark in New York City, and have for a long time, have great reputations. So it was really like get to the back of the line, unless you came to New York already knowing twenty people that were going to immediately — but I actually just came with a bass and a suitcase and I had a phone number in my book for Murray Wall.

MR: Murray Wall, yeah.

NP: And so no, I didn't know if I was going to — I really left Australia saying I'm just going for the summer, the New York summer, the American summer, I'm just going for a few months, I'll see you maybe in October or November. Very vague. It totally scared the life out of my parents. You know I was 24, and just brave I guess. Crazy or brave, I don't know which one. But I rose to the challenge. Soon after I met this Australian girl and I worked in fashion for eight months. Because I really didn't know if I was ever going to get — you know I had a gig with George Coleman Junior's mother, Gloria Coleman, who

is a wonderful piano player. I think it paid like 30 bucks or something like that. It was like a lunchtime gig at the Film Center. So I did Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday I worked in fashion selling prints to fashion designers. And that world was crazy. That was a crazy world. The whole fashion world. Skinny girls and gay guys pretty much. So I thought well, this is something different. You know, very competitive and but interesting kind of, it was creative. And so I did that for eight months. And I sold all these prints [inaudible] paisleys, whatever the fashion designers, you know, prints on paper. Sales. It was hard work. It was my first job. So I did that for a while and then on Thursday and Friday I did lunchtimes with George Coleman Junior on drums and Gloria Coleman on piano, at the Film Center in New York.

MR: This is George Coleman's —

NP: Son. And his mother, who passed away recently in Philadelphia. A wonderful piano player. But they kind of took me in and it was just really a beautiful experience. I think I did that for like a year even, just playing there a couple of times a week, and it was just like a way to get your feet wet. It was a fun gig you know, it was just for people having coffee before they went to the movie. I didn't care you know what I mean? You just want to play and get out there. And then at night if I could afford it I'd go to Bradley's. And my teacher was Rufus Reid at the time.

MR: Rufus Reid.

NP: So I'd go down to see Rufus and the piano players and trios that played at Bradley's. You know I could walk there. It was wonderful. It was a great time.

MR: And you're absorbing just watching these people, how they played the gig and how they behaved and all that good stuff.

NP: Yeah. Basically. Pretty much. And then after eight months I had a gig in Switzerland so I quit my day job, and that was early '95. And actually they offered me a full time job in fashion with commission and all. I could have actually gone down this whole other road in New York. I'd actually been a musician in Sydney and then just gone to New York and then I could have woooh, I could have made money, I could have done, it was kind of like almost too easy do you know what I mean? Plus I do — that's not my love. I like nice clothes, who doesn't? But it's like that's not a passion at all. So I said no thank you and I just decided to try to figure it out.

MR: Well you have to be passionate about music to make a living at it, isn't that right?

NP: Oh absolutely. You've got to love it and I love the music community. And the best musicians are, oh most musicians are really mostly good people to be around and hang out with. You know? The best times in my life are times on the road. And the funniest times in my life are times on the road.

MR: Like can you pull one out of your memory? I know that's a hard question.

NP: No it is, it's really hard to do that.

MR: Yeah it is.

NP: Because what happens with that, it's like saying an Australian expression. I have to be in the mood or someone has to remind me of something to spur that on and it's hard to do that. There were really funny times watching Les Paul be the road. Now here he's like 90 years old and he's going out to California and just to watch him around the celebrities and people that came to the gig and just to see how he handled it, and then if there was a problem with the money and watching him just stand backstage and not go on stage, whatever. And people waiting for us. And there were times where I was like, this is interesting. And then the bus came back and they sorted it all out and then all right, then we'll go back on. We didn't know exactly what happened but it was all okay. Stuff like that. There were so many times when like, wow.

MR: I guess you can learn from all those things, but it seems like he didn't suffer fools gladly.

NP: Les? No. No. No. He was always good to me. Always good to me. You know sometimes he'd get mad because I went on the road. I couldn't be there every Monday night for ten years, you know what I mean? I was really trying to, I love going to Europe and playing. I love going to certain places and I just couldn't turn that down to stay in New York for Monday night and maybe some other gigs during the week that might turn up. It was hard to make a living just on that Monday night. So you know sometimes — but he usually said, "We missed you." And sometimes that's all he'd say the whole night. But if we had a really great show he'd say, "That was fun" or something, "that was good." And if it wasn't such a good show or he wasn't happy with his playing he wouldn't say really anything. But it was never really negative, ever, towards me or the musicians. And he enjoyed it. And he had a good time. And he laughed all the time. And he was funny.

MR: And now that gig — you have a series of different people who come in?

NP: Yeah. It's the Tribute to Les Paul Night every Monday, so same as before I'm there most Monday nights, but sometimes I'm not if I'm on the road.

MR: Is it your job to send in a sub?

NP: Absolutely. Jay Leonhart subs for me.

MR: Oh. How funny is that. That's funny.

NP: Yeah. Well I wanted someone that could also sing a tune, and Jay has a wonderful repertoire, and you know, comedic songs and playing the bass essentially.

MR: Right. Yeah, that's funny. So are you a bass player who sings, or are you a singer who plays the bass?

NP: I'm a bass player that sings. You know I recently did a cabaret show where it was more about the singing. In fact I was being directed by this director of this cabaret show who had me put down the bass and sit on a stool and sing some songs. And that to me was

more about the singing. But if you think about the cabaret role, the cabaret role is someone singing, that's what the focus is on.

MR: Right.

NP: Sometimes only just with a piano player. Do you know what I mean? The cabaret, this is where I think the cabaret is different maybe from jazz, it's much more about the song and talking to the audience and connecting there, which was good discipline for me, to have to be there, to that extreme. I sometimes think if I'm going to do a cabaret show I still want to shift it a bit more towards jazz, Do you know what I mean? I still want to do instrumentals. I still want to keep the focus on instrumental jazz peppered with some nice tunes. So for me it's hard to do a whole cabaret show.

MR: Is there a thing about just feeling more exposed to the audience if it's just you and the microphone? You know when you have a bass you've got this other thing.

NP: Yeah I know, and I have had people say to me over the years you should just really put the bass down. I don't know look at Esperanza Spaulding, you know, a good example. She is out there playing and singing, and now she is really doing a whole lot of different stuff. I'm not caught up on her latest material but you know, she's doing it in her way. It's very interesting, but she's playing and singing. And honestly I'm feeling now that the bass lines I'm playing when I play the bass actually dictates how I sing so I really have to separate the two when I'm in the studio because they don't like the leaking and they don't like this and they want —

MR: What was that?

NP: If you've got the vocals then they don't want the bass leaking into that, so in the studio, so far, I've done everything separate. It's not really by choice it's just because the engineers want to do it that way, or the producer. I've done four Japanese records and they've all been done that way, and they're all vocals on every track. So it's a lot of work. It's okay, because then there's a discipline on doing a couple of takes vocally until you're really in the song you know. But you know, I prefer live, where you sing and you play at the same time.

MR: How much time do you get — like you're on a lot of the Arbors recordings now, and how much time do you typically get. This is a long question. But how many hours do those LPs — yeah LPs — do those CDs actually take, and do you know what's coming before you get there?

NP: Uh good question. Okay assuming I'm not the leader I have no clue what's coming until I get there. So the session usually is booked for two four hour days, 12 to 4 on a Monday, 12 to 4 on a Tuesday. They're usually consecutive days. And so you turn up at 12 and you might get a bunch of tunes in your hand. You might get a tune for a song. You know what I mean? Like we're doing this song, here's the music. Do that song. Here's the next

song. Here's — either you know it or they'll give you a chart you know what I mean? If they've got a specific arrangement they'll always pull a chart. And so if I'm not the leader I have no clue what we're doing. If I'm the leader and I think the musicians don't need to know until they get there, you know what I mean, like when you're playing with such wonderful players like Warren Vache and Harry Allen, they can read and play through anything. You don't really have to worry about it, you just turn up and you get to rehearse it. If it's hard you rehearse it. But then if I'm leading myself and I want to sing some then you do two days of instrumental and then usually I come in on another day and finish up the vocals or something.

MR: How much control do you get over — I mean you have a producer whose in a sense paying for the session?

NP: Mat Domber?

MR: Yeah.

NP: It depends who the producer is.

MR: Who says, "Well I like take 1, and he likes take 2."

NP: Mat is pretty cool. Mat is very cool. He is so laid back. He's like oh it all sounds good to me. He's pretty much that. You know what I mean? But sometimes he really has an opinion about it, it's like, "I like that." "No, the other one's better." Sometimes he will actually say what he likes. It's generally up to the band leader on those sessions. So often I'm hearing on a bass solo like oh, I hope they don't keep this track. But they'll say keep this track, and I'm not the leader, I have to — because it's a time thing. So if the gig, if you're not the leader on the session, you can't be tying up people's time, like, "I want to do that bass solo again, I don't like it." You know you can't be tying up people's time that way. Do you know what I mean? You have to be respectful, it's their record. If they're happy with it or if they didn't like it they could say to you, "Why don't you run the first four bars of that, you didn't sound so great" you know what I mean? The other thing I'll do in a session, because I do love recording and I love — you know I don't like wasting time. I don't like too much talking time or eating time or, you now. I like to, you know, like let's get to it. Because you do it on a roll. When you're doing a take, I find that you really have to be aware of, because it's tiny, four hours and four hours, well rock records get done in six months. You know what I mean? I mean you really have to be aware of if you make a mistake or you don't make the right changes at a point or you miss the ending or you didn't even make the beginning. You have to make a mental alert as you go through the tape. And you can say, at the end of the tape, I need to overdub bars 16 and 17. You know what I mean? Because they may not be hearing it if someone's talking and they don't hear it, then they get the product and they come up and say, "Oh, what happened to Nicki there? Oh, she missed that." But if you make a mental note you

can say listen I need to overdub these bars and I know I was nowhere near it. So that's another good thing in the studio I think is to be aware of it in terms of — because that might be the take they pick.

MR: Then they can actually punch you in for a couple of bars.

NP: Exactly. While they're recording it's incredible. I have to thank Les for that, multi-track recording. So it's fast, it's easy — and working with engineers like Jimmy Czak up at Nola who does almost all of my New York recording.

MR: Boy that place has been there for a long time.

NP: And often Jimmy will hear it, Jimmy is like, "Nicki, play the ending again, it wasn't clean." "You're right." Bam. It really takes like not even two minutes. It's amazingly fast now.

MR: That place has been there a long time.

NP: A long time.

MR: I mean I remember guys that played in the 30s I think. Maybe not that long. But it must be neat to be in that kind of a place, like Milt Hinton played here.

NP: It's just a good energy. It's a great energy up there. It really is. It's always a nice vibe. It's funny, it's not too serious. Sometimes it gets serious if someone's not happy with the music or the musicians or something, but really generally it's a good time. People pop in all the time. It's a great energy.

MR: How do you learn all the tunes that you need to know as a bass player? And you must have to tell your students something about that.

NP: Well, it's funny, sometimes there's two schools of thought in jazz. Bucky Pizzarelli, when he was at William Paterson, boy, I mean I knew some that studied with him, he really got on kids' cases. I think Bucky can do it and get away with it, he's just so wonderful. He'd get on kids' cases about learning tunes and having repertoire. I'm not sure if that's always really the focus in schools. You know what I mean? I'm not sure about that. There was a set repertoire that I had to learn when I was back at the conservatorium, and it was like, I don't know, maybe 25 tunes a year. I was only there for two years.

MR: Did that education prepare you very well for the real world?

NP: It's a good question isn't it. So much of jazz I think is really taught on the bandstand. I'd say yes and no in a way. I had good teachers at the conservatorium. I had great teachers. And you know we'd be playing all the time. You are playing tunes, I was playing tunes back then that I still play on gigs today. I met some wonderful people, Mike Nock, a great piano player who is in New York, was one of my ensemble teachers. Don Burrows, string and jazz legend.

MR: What was his name?

NP: Don Burrows. He's a string, he's a legend there, he's just a great musician, a great guy. He started this jazz course at the Sydney Conservatorium. And I was the first girl student of my bass teacher. It is funny. And he was a great bass player. I don't know. There's different ways of — sometimes yeah, sometimes I felt the classes were a waste of time, but I was there with my friends, my sister, and there were five of us from Newcastle that went to the Sydney Con at the same time. We all went to Sydney. Some of us shared a house and we went to the Sydney Con, and all five of us are now professional musicians in different parts of the world. My sister and I are in New York. Adrian Muse is one of the best trombone players in Germany. Andrew Dickenson is a fine drummer, always busy, in Sydney. And then John Foreman, he was the only one that didn't go with us to the Sydney Con because he was too young, but we had this little group. We had this band together. And he was like 13 at the time, he couldn't even reach the pedals on the piano. He became the Paul Shaffer of Australia. I mean it was like he had a big MD [Music Director] gig on music shows, he wrote the theme for the Australian Olympics, he's like the MD for Australian Idol, you know what I mean? He's like a household name in Australia. I thought that was really wonderful that the five of us from just playing at a jazz camp together and playing music together as like teenagers, actually went to the Con and there was a career. I don't know what the question was.

MR: Well I'm trying to envision you going to one of your many gigs that are, not throw together is not the right word, but it's not a working band, and someone calls a tune and you don't know it.

NP: Ah. Happens a lot. Happens a lot to me.

MR: So what do you do? Do you say "can we not play that?"

NP: You know, no I can't do that. I'm the bass.

MR: I know, you're the bass player.

NP: Right. I cannot. It happens a lot. Especially on gigs where you haven't played with this person really ever, you know what I mean? But now they're leading a set and they're shooting, maybe you know this song but it's really obscure to me. Very obscure. And so even if you've been doing this, like I have been professionally for 22 years now, and know quite a few songs, I still get stumped. There might be one or two songs in a set where I'm like what is that from 1910? I mean really, I can't, with these crazy titles. And you're like well sometimes, if it's a complicated tune, I ask, is it easy or is it hard? If it's easy my ears will guide me. If the piano player is playing a dominant line I know where it's going. You know what I mean?

MR: You hope.

NP: Yeah.

MR: You hope, unless it's sort of deceptive.

NP: If it's a really hard tune with a lot of keys I'll say, "Can you write it out for me." If I don't get a chance to then I've just got to help make this happen. And sometimes if I'm really not getting it I'll be looking at him like what is it? That's just one of the hardest things about being in the rhythm section. Because often the piano players will get to say if it's too hard. The piano players are very vocal about that, oh I really don't know it. The piano players don't want to be showing up not knowing chords to the song. But then again if they do and you don't know it, well then you've got to rely on them to teach it to you. Generally by the second chorus or third, generally after the head hopefully you have it. If it's not the most difficult tune in the world. If it's "Waltz for Debbie" and you've never played it, then you need a chart, I'm sorry, but you can't really expect musicians to play a very difficult song that they haven't heard before. That's hard work.

MR: And as far as a leader, it doesn't serve the leader well either. Like I'm going to make you play it. Well okay but what you're going to get you're not going to be that happy with, it's only going to reflect on you.

NP: Yeah. You get to the bridge and you may not have any chords underneath you. Because they thought they knew the tune and then they get to the bridge and they start playing the bridge of another tune and, good luck. It happens.

MR: And sometimes the piano player is waiting for you to hit the note.

NP: Exactly. And I've guided just as many piano players. I've guided piano players on the top trying to teach tunes too. And it's just that thing where we go okay, we're here to learn. Music is about learning. And sometimes in those situations you go home with like, "I like that song we played, what was that called again?" And you actually go home with a new song that you might seek out and you might play again, and now you've learned it, on that gig. And that's how it works for me.

MR: Well I've seen you play a bunch of times now and I was thinking to myself, like I can't imagine why a band leader wouldn't want you in their band.

NP: Oh that's so sweet.

MR: I'm also wondering, is there — I'm trying to think how to phrase this question — do you have to be careful of sending the spotlight towards you?

NP: You know there is, a lot of times, and a lot of singers, in fact most singers, that don't want me on the bandstand with them. And it's nothing about music. They don't want any attention away from what they're doing, from themselves. So having another woman onstage some would feel is a distraction to them. God forbid it's another woman. It's just the way it is. So there are a few exceptions to that. I think Anne Hampton Calloway is one of the coolest women I've worked with, you know. She doesn't care. She's just so good at what she does, she's so confident, she's great. So there are the exceptions to the rule. Most singers aren't that way. So I generally do not work with any singers. And I can

only put it down to that fact, it's like why have another woman on stage if I can have X Y Z of guy bass players that won't take attention away from — not that I'm trying to. If the gig is just me accompanying, I'm just in the background doing my work, you know? But it's just the way it's perceived from a woman's point of view you know. But so the sex situation, I'm really, I'm just happy to play with good people. There's also a lot of people that just wouldn't hire a girl musician, for whatever reason, still.

MR: Still.

NP: Yeah. Still. Yeah. It happens. And does it happen less? I'm sure it happens less. But does it still happen? Yeah. It doesn't bother me. I still work. I still travel and maybe I don't want to work with them. Do you know what I mean? It's like I don't really care so much about the politics anymore as long as I'm playing with good people and as long as I have the respect of the musicians that I admire. I mean really who cares in the end. You know what I mean? If you start worrying about the gigs you're not doing it can get really dark and bitter quickly.

MR: Well it's like referring to Marian McPartland as "one of the best of the women jazz musicians."

NP: Yeah. And still today. You know and certain clubs that shall remain nameless, but trying to get a gig there is, you might get a night on a "Woman in Jazz" week. You know and it's kind of like wow, you still have those? Well I guess we do. And Billy Taylor has a wonderful Woman in Jazz Festival at the Kennedy Center. You know, but he's doing it for the right reason. He's doing it because he wants to highlight women leaders more. You know, so it's not only women playing. And of course I'm friends with everybody in Diva and there's a lot of wonderful musicians in Diva, where I started, in the Diva big band. My sister plays in Diva, and it's a great band and I like everyone in the band. But there's still some issues around it. We try not to take too much time about it.

MR: Well do you think it would get to the point where the Diva big band could just be the something-else big band. I mean the title of the band calls attention to the fact that this is an all-women band.

NP: Yeah. Well I guess it gets into the marketing thing. I mean I think it's hard enough for a big band to get work. In fact my sister leaves today to go on a jazz cruise with Diva. Anyway, I think if you've been around for ten years and you get gigs with the name Diva and it's working for you then why change it. I mean it's hard enough with a name change to try to get gigs. I think it works for them. You know they are kind of a Diva-ish kind of band. You know what I mean? They really sock it to you. They're a really fully charged band I think, with good players.

MR: So the name does have some significance behind it. Because the word "Diva" is used a lot these days.

NP: Yeah it's overused and it's usually in reference to a woman who thinks she's all that or whatever. You know what I mean? But I think it's fine for the band. And they sound good.

MR: Is there a double standard for the way a woman musician has to try to look on a gig as opposed to guys. I mean guys can, I don't know if guys think that much about what they wear.

NP: No they don't. Sometimes it's really obvious with musicians that they really put no thought, in fact that shirt and that tie, really? I mean it's not about fashion, you know, playing music, but it is about looking presentable. And it's good to definitely look presentable. Getting back to your point, getting back to the question again, sorry.

MR: I just wondered if you feel like you have to pay more attention to how you dress.

NP: No I used to try to dress way more like a guy when I was first starting out in music. Oh yeah. And I was so conscious of not being taken seriously. There was one instance when I got called for a gig and they said, "Is this Nick Parrott?" And I said, "Well actually it's Nicki." "A bass player?" "Yeah, Nicki Parrott." Click. You know what I mean? So it was like instances where I was like really fragile. I was still trying to learn how to play. And I was 18 or 19 and I noticed that guys I grew up with in Newcastle were getting all these great gigs and it was the first time I was aware that, oh God, I'm a woman in this business. You know what I mean? It was like the first time I'd really become aware of this is going to be different for me, to them, in a way. It was like subtle differences. But I've been one of the lucky ones though. I've been a professional musician for, like I said, for basically 22 years with an eight month stint in fashion. In these days it doesn't matter, you know, woman, man, black, white, anything. It's just a more difficult time to be a musician. So all of that stuff is gone by the wayside because economically it's a challenge whoever you are. It doesn't matter anymore. That's how I feel now. I feel it's pretty much an even playing field, you know what I mean, where there are gigs to be had and you have to work really hard at getting them it seems.

MR: Have you noticed that it's gotten harder in your 22 years?

NP: Yes. Because even when I first came here and I was doing gigs on Broadway, there was still a happening studio scene in New York. There were still things going on. I mean I think that time in New York was really great. I got hooked up with a whole corporate party scene at the end of '94, and I got sponsored by this club date organization, you know, sponsored for an 01 visa. So I was actually able to get legal. This would be much harder to do, I mean what I did then, now. It's a different time in a post 9/11 world and the politics are much different now, and you know it was a much easier time then. You know there were all these gigs and corporate, and all that, and so I got sponsored for an 01 visa.

MR: 01?

NP: 01 artist visa for three years. So I had a sponsor and I worked with her on and off for the next three years, and started paying taxes and got a Social Security card. So within six months of being here I was a legal resident.

MR: Are you a citizen now?

NP: No I am not. In fact this week I have to go and renew my green card, and then citizenship. I want to be a citizen by this time next year, so I'll let you know if I've crossed that hurdle. It's a lot of paperwork. And the hardest question for me is two questions on the citizenship paper that are very hard for musicians, namely your employers, and namely where you've been since the green card. So if not five years, if not ten years, well where have you been outside the country. Well I did so many one-nighters I don't even remember. I've got two passports to go through, you know, it's like wow. So there's a couple of questions that aren't really geared for us. All they really want to know is were you in the Middle East at all. That's what they want to know. But they have to know exactly where you've been. Maybe you were in Pakistan. Maybe you were in places that are on the watch. So it's very hard. The process is going to take me a lot of time to go through. Daunting for someone who's not tip-top organized.

MR: Wow. I mean do you save you calendars from year to year?

NP: Yeah I've got my calendars saved. But sometimes I would write, literally, when I was doing a lot of traveling — "Europe" — "Back from Europe" and that would be like three weeks. What was I doing those three weeks. Honestly I don't even know what country I was in sometimes if I went from Warsaw to Czechoslovakia. I might not even have written, I might have been asleep the whole time and not written in my book.

MR: Oh that's funny. I just was talking to another musician about that fact, that like people think that your travel is so great because you get to go to all these places.

NP: It is. It's one of the perks. And I never forget that. When I meet people that haven't been out of the country. And you're like ten years older than me and you've been once to Europe? Oh, you've got to go back. And you've got to go to this place. And I feel for them in a way. You know what I mean? Not that — there's so many beautiful places to go in America of course, it's a wonderful place to be, of course. But you need a comparison point. And every time I go back to Europe and come back I have a different perspective. I cook differently. I live a little differently. You know what I mean? And then I have a different perspective on now I'm on the outside looking in. And I don't know I just feel it's when we cook, it really is. It's hard work, but it's so good. Absolutely.

MR: In the really small sense though, sometimes I envision you and drummers especially playing a club date in New York and logistically I would think that's probably a pain sometimes. Like parking your car.

NP: You can say that. I don't know how many gigs I've done in midtown where you really have to call someone. "I need help." Sometimes I have to take a PA, particularly if they want me to sing and play the whole night. So you've got a PA, an acoustic bass and an amplifier and the gig is upstairs at the Crown Plaza on 42nd Street. How do you do this? Except put your hazards on, panic, get help, get your stuff inside, make sure someone is watching it, go and park. It's a nightmare. But you find a way. The best thing about — you really have to be organized, you know what I mean? I mean the more organization and the more time you give yourself, you know, the better off you will be. And you have to go and do your own research. Sometimes the best parking will be a comp and you can print out a coupon to get cheaper parking somewhere, you know. And you have to know do the streets go this way on that street? You really have to know midtown Manhattan to survive it. Yeah it's rough. That's the hardest part. To me it's not the playing and singing and smiling on those gigs, you know, the corporate gigs. All it is is turn up, play, sing and smile and that doing what the gig requires you know, you're back in the music. But the other stuff, wow. That's a challenge.

MR: What does a gig like that pay if you don't mind my asking.

NP: Um it varies. Well it's as low as $300 really or even lower. But if I don't sing or do anything else it could be lower. But maybe $300 to $5, $6 even more. Generally not more these days.

MR: Well around here people would be very happy with that.

NP: Yeah absolutely.

MR: See I'm sure it's different. But people who go to play like in Small's?

NP: Yeah.

MR: What do those gigs pay, or do they?

NP: Well I don't really do any gigs under a hundred bucks. And there are a lot of hundred buck gigs and they have stayed a hundred bucks for a very long time. You know what I mean? So the pay hasn't gone up in New York in a very long time. You could go as low as, my goodness, my sister did a gig there for like fifteen bucks. I'm like that's one drink and a tip in New York these days. She makes money in other ways. She's one of the best copyists there is. You know what I mean? Like she does other gigs that actually do pay some money. So you kind of weigh everything up. Sometimes, some gigs, I did a hundred buck gig the other night in midtown. And I had a ball. And I was with a Lincoln Center drummer who works with Wynton and everybody. He was happy to play for a hundred bucks. We were all saying how fun it was the next day, "That was great last

night." That's the most fun I've had on a gig in ages, you know what I mean? So for me it was a hundred bucks but it wasn't about the hundred bucks. You know club owners know this too, that we want to play music, and often take advantage of us. I just have a bit of a problem with some of the kids coming out of the colleges and playing for twenty, thirty bucks and fifty bucks even. It's really just not helping to standardize anything. So playing for nothing is not a great idea generally.

MR: Let me — I'm watching the time here — but I just wanted to toss a couple of names at you. We were taking about Kenny Davern earlier. And he's the guy who first gave me your name.

NP: You're kidding.

MR: Yep. Because we were taking about who to bring up to Hamilton.

NP: You never caught me with Kenny.

MR: No.

NP: We did a lot of gigs though, before he passed. You know I was subbing for I'm trying to name the bass player that he played with, Greg —

MR: Greg Cohen.

NP: Greg Cohen. And so between me and Greg, we did most of Kenny's gigs in the last couple of years. I loved playing with him. I liked the fact that he had a different approach to playing that music completely. In other words, he liked the openness, I loved the way James Chirillo played with him, because I felt like there was a lot of space. And I love space in music. And I don't feel sometimes there is enough of it. It gets a little crowded there. And I never felt that way on Kenny's gigs. I felt there was so much — Kenny never wasted notes. He just had one of the best sounds I've ever heard on clarinet. And he wanted you to play. He didn't want you to take short solos. He encouraged you to play on solos sometimes. And I learned a lot. And sometimes it wasn't feeling right and he'd turn around and say something you know what I mean? And he'd scare the hell out of you. But it was all out of encouragement. I just that that it really was on your side.

MR: He wanted it to be good.

NP: He wanted it to be really good. Really high standards. He really did. And often it was because he believed in you that he would say something in the first place. And I was pleased with that. This gets back to the women thing. I think sometimes guys are really scared to say something to a woman musician that they might say to a guy. And I'm like no, I'm one of the guys. I'm the one that has 22 years on the road. You can't shock me. You know what I mean? I've always wanted to be treated like one of the guys. So tell me if I'm rushing or slowing down. Just tell me. I might get a little upset maybe back in the hotel room later, but I'm going to listen to you and I'm going to say okay, good. Maybe I wasn't aware of that. Thank you. You know what I mean? Because how else do you grow

as a musician? I think of someone like Kenny as having the experience of playing with really great bass players and knows what he wants. Then tell me. Because I'm younger and maybe I just don't know.

MR: Well that was the next guy I was going to ask you about. Were you able to rub elbows with Milt Hinton?

NP: That's all I was able to do. Because when I started going to Arbors jazz parties and I started to see him play he was already in a wheelchair. I remember one quick story, have you got time for that? There was an Arbors jazz party almost a decade ago, maybe nine years ago, maybe ten years ago now. And it was when I first started doing Arbors jazz parties and they first invited me to play with whoever. You know, not to play with Diva or FivePlay and the other bands, but to actually play with whomever. Which was a brave of him and just so wonderful of him to embrace me that way. And so we had one set and Michael Moore was leading the set. And this was a star cast of bass players. I was petrified. It was Jay [Leonhart], Michael Moore, I think Phil Flanigan, Milt wasn't there, this was a set for Milt. And it was a 20 minute set on a Sunday. And I haven't gone through all the bass players that I'll get back to, Keter Betts was there. And I might be forgetting a couple, but there was a lot of bass players. In those days we all had a bass because it was before the airlines really started coming down. But I think we all had a bass. And you know Michael said, "I don't know how long Milt's going to be around so we need to do this for him again, so we're going to take as long as it takes to a tribute to Milt Hinton. It may not be 20 minutes but we're going to take as long as it takes." And I was like, "Right on, Michael. You can do that. You've been here a lot, you've known Milt for years." It was so, it was the most moving, even thinking about it it was emotional. It was probably an hour set. And it probably ended up being more like an hour set come to think of it. Because what we did was we did two or three duets. Michael had these two part — he did an album with Rufus Reid. So he had a two part bass thing that he had in his book, which was melody and harmony and bass line. So we all stood up and rehearsed in the morning. And we all took a part and played on the stage two or three pieces. And then we all did personal tributes with Milt on stage. So, and this is when you've got to have something up your sleeve. You've got all these people on the stage. You've got all these people. Jay's got a song. Phil's doing some kind of bebop thing, and all these people, and everyone has something great. Well I had worked out, you know, I think it's good to work out stuff sometimes. I had worked out kind of a big introduction on "The Man I Love," with double stops you know what I mean, completely worked out. There's nothing wrong with that, when you're front and center. So I had worked out something on "The Man I Love," and Milt turned to Jay and said, "you've got to get rid of the girl, she'll steal our gigs." So that was the most fun I ever had on one of those jazz

parties. Because we were all on the same page. And it was a standing ovation. It was like one of those, you know what I mean, it's like, if a promoter came and said we're going to do this, it might not have come out so eloquent and so natural. You know it was bass players doing their tribute, the way they wanted to do it. So that's my memory of Milt and seeing him towards the end. And at the end of that set he got up and sang "Old Man Time."

MR: Oh right. Yeah, the way he does it.

NP: And it was so moving.

MR: You know everybody who met the guy had his memories. He fell asleep on my shoulder once. That's my memory.

NP: Really?

MR: Yeah. I mean we were in a van going with the Statesmen of Jazz and I was riding with them. And he fell asleep on my shoulder, and I'm going [gasp] Milt Hinton. But some of those people have this magnetism to them, like you feel better after you've been able to just be near them.

NP: I think so too.

MR: It was like really.

NP: Do you know what I mean? For those moments. And they don't come around every day. At other times the gigs are just, well it was okay, you know. And sometimes it doesn't sound so great. It's okay. Or most of the time I'm playing with people, they're good gigs. I'm very fortunate. But those gigs are like wow, those are the gigs that stand out in your brain. And it's like pinch me, am I here? They're the ones that are special.

MR: Well you know I'm very glad the day that you had the conflict with the piano exam and the race, that you chose the piano exam. Because if you think about it, for one thing your career as a sprinter would probably be over by now.

NP: You have to be so good. I mean even to just get, you know what I mean? I enjoy it. In fact I still want to run fast sometimes. I mean like I'll be doing a jog and I'm like let me see if I've still got it. You know, but that also was about freedom and expressing myself with that freedom. You know when I was running I felt free of the world. It wasn't a single thing that I was searching for, it was that I was trying to get it through two different ways. Music gave me the out of being disconnected from reality and church and school and bullies and all the stuff you go through as kids, and that's why they've got to make more importance of music and art in schools, because kids needs to escape in a productive way. It's true. And running was also, I know sports gets a lot of attention, but kids need to be active. They need to have healthy lives. And I think when you're a kid — you'll have some time to get fat, because you know what I mean? Because you want to be fit.

MR: Do you have any long term goals?

NP: There's places I want to play and people I want to play with. You know I focus on it at different times. This is a quieter month for me so I'll explore that again. I sense some — you know you've got to be prepared when you're in this business for the rejection too. I might want to play at this place but they might not want to have me. So for whatever reason, too, there could be a million different reasons. So you may not even get an email back but you still keep trying. You've got to keep trying. So yeah, there's a lot of stuff I still want to do. There's a lot of projects I still want to do.

MR: Write more songs, you've written some nice tunes.

NP: Right.

MR: I like that one you wrote "I Think You're the One" —

NP: "You're The One I Think I've Waited For."

MR: Right. I like the "I think" in that title.

NP: It's a little complex.

MR: Is it hard with all the traveling and so forth and the way your life is, is it hard to have a established relationships?

NP: Yes. I think every musician is going to say yes to this. If they so no, not really, then they've just got really lucky. I mean really. Because you see the wonderful relationships. You and I were at a dinner table with Bucky and Ruth. And it's like you just take after them, hanging out together, having a good time together. It's wonderful. It's so wonderful to see but it's also so rare. So yes, right now I'm single. I was married. But I have a wonderful guy in my life so I would definitely tie the knot again. It's very hard. It's been very hard for the last few years, just my whole life actually, just to understand that I'm a musician and I travel and I'm a little ambitious, and really this is my life. And I mean I have had boyfriends who say you can't go away this much and well another reason is economic too, I've got to — living in New York ain't cheap living by yourself.

MR: You have to go where the work is.

NP: You have to go where the work is, and often I'm going out of town to play with some people I really like playing with, I'm going to have fun, I'm not staying in town waiting for the phone call for the local gigs. I might not be doing something as great you know what I mean? No anyway, so it is hard. And now I'm in a relationship that I really want to — interview me in ten years. No but that I really want to see into marriage. I really want all that. It's just really hard to have as a musician.

MR: Well I appreciate your time today. It's been very enjoyable.

NP: Very enjoyable for me. Good questions. Challenging questions.

MR: And good luck with the Klezmer tonight and the whole thing.

NP: I'm sure it'll be great. He's always great. One thing about Dave, he puts on a great show. Sorry you won't be there but it's okay.

MR: Well we are expecting you at Hamilton again next fall.

NP: Which is lovely. Thank you for asking me. Yeah.

MR: Well good luck to you.

NP: Much appreciated.